



Italy

THE BOOT-SHAPED COUNTRY of Italy stretches from the mountainous north down to the Mediterranean Sea. For much of its history, Italy consisted of city-states—such as Florence and Venice—and was united only in 1870. Regional differences in Italy are huge, as each region has its own cuisine, customs, and dialect, and is geographically quite distinct. As a result, many Italians identify themselves first by region and then by country. The largest division, however, is between the rich north and the poorer south—a rugged region with several active volcanoes and the occasional severe earthquake. The mainland of Italy includes two tiny independent states—San Marino and Vatican City.

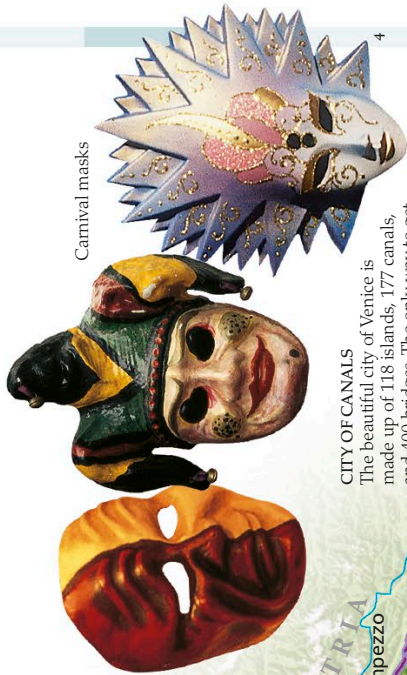


Andrea Bocelli

Vatican City has a permanent population of only about 1,000 people, although more than 3,000 come to work in the city-state each day.

HOME OF OPERA

The idea of setting drama to music originated in Italy during the 16th century. Since then, Italian composers such as Rossini, Verdi, and Puccini have made opera the most popular musical form in Italy. Many cities have their own opera houses.



Carnival masks

CITY OF CANALS

The beautiful city of Venice is made up of 118 islands, 177 canals, and 400 bridges. The only way to get around is to walk or take a boat: a *vaporetto*, *motoscafo*, or *motonave*. The most distinctive boat, however, is the gondola. Each year, in the days before Ash Wednesday, Venice hosts a carnival when the city celebrates with fireworks and everyone wears spectacular masks.



COLOSSEUM
One of Rome's greatest sights is the Colosseum, which opened in 80 CE. Deadly gladiatorial combats and animal fights were staged here before crowds of up to 55,000 people.



The oval-shaped Colosseum stood at 620 ft (189 m) high.

FOOTBALL FANS
Italians are mad about football and fanatically follow the performance of teams such as Juventus, AC Milan, Inter, and Roma. Italian teams frequently win major European competitions, and the national team has won the World Cup four times—in 1934, 1938, 1982, and 2006.



Corsica (to France)